

Barnstorming start: Shikhar Dhawan made a stunning Test debut in 2013, scoring a century off just 85 balls against Australia in Mohali - the fastest by a debutant. He finished with a match-winning 187. PTI

Have you ever seen him under pressure? I have not. It is not easy to tackle international challenges with such an attitude. If you talk to Shikhar, the toughest of cricket is nothing but a minor obstacle."

Dhawan had come to Roshanara following a disappointing ODI (in Visakhapatnam) against Australia, where he was out second ball for nothing. He had toiled to gain a place in the Indian team and was discouraged when he was ignored for a long time in 2012. The failure to keep his place in the Indian squad tormented him.

"I would ask myself, 'Am I good enough to play at the international level?' I knew I had the talent; I was working hard like anyone else, but something was missing," Dhawan once recalled.

His coach, Tarak Sinha, was perturbed when Dhawan spoke about quitting the game. For Madan Sharma, the coach dedicated to working with Dhawan at Sonnet, it was a challenging phase. But Dhawan returned to his rightful place with that extraordinary Test debut in Mohali.

With a philosophical bent, Dhawan loved to analyse his game and character. "I criticise myself and appreciate myself. I am my best friend. I love cricket, but I have learnt that one can be in love and still be detached. If I am dropped from the India team, I can't let it bring me down. It will hurt big time, but then there is life outside cricket, too," he said once.

His life outside of cricket is a lovable world. Charity and friendship matter to him. His competitive flair on the field is reflected in his profound calmness off it. He learnt to play the flute and aspired to perform on a public platform. Retirement at 38 would give Dhawan the time to achieve his ambition.



Shikhar in numbers

Format	M	Inn	Runs	HS	Ave.	S/R	100s	50s
Tests	34	58	2315	190	40.61	66.94	7	5
ODIs	167	164	6793	143	44.11	91.35	17	39
T20Is	68	66	1759	92	27.92	126.36	0	11